

“If God is male, then male is God”

Daly's aphorism essentially underlines that because we have presented God as exclusively male, this has elevated men as closer to the divine, which has been used as a justification to reinforce and legitimise patriarchy. However, Daly's argument will be challenged in two ways: Firstly, by denying the antecedent, it will be contended that in the Old Testament, God is not conceived of as fitting into the human construct of gender, therefore, God should be reimagined as genderless. Since a theological critique of Daly's claim does not negate the sociological argument, it will secondly be put forward that we can redeem the liberating core of the Bible and break down the outdated association of masculinity and divinity.

It might be alluring to put forward that God is male as the Bible consistently employs masculine pronouns such as 'He' and 'Him' and uses anthropomorphic language when depicting God. Therefore, this would naturally entail that 'God is male.' In Matthew 6:9, God seems intrinsically linked to fatherhood 'in heaven' and the Lord is 'our father' in Isaiah 64:8. In Psalm, God is the 'King of all the Earth' and in Timothy God is 'the blessed and only Sovereign, the King of kings and Lord of lords.' Kingship is a strongly masculine role in the ancient world, used frequently in depicting God, hence Daly's aphorism would be seen to hold true.

However, in the Old Testament, Yahweh, the God of Israelites, is depicted using feminine imagery. For example, Yahweh's motherly love and nurture is exemplified as 'when Israel was a child' Yahweh 'bent down to feed them' and 'led them with cords of human kindness' (Hosea 11:1-4). Furthermore, in Isaiah 49:15, God's love is likened to a mother's compassion for her nursing infant, and earlier, in Isaiah 42:14, God 'now like a woman in childbirth' 'cries out. This is also reinforced as God is depicted as a midwife, bringing a child safely from the womb in Psalm 22:9-10 and in Numbers 11:12, God is detailed as a nurse, carrying Israel like a child. Lastly, in Genesis 3:21, Yahweh clothes Adam and Eve after their sin, like a mother dressing her children, depicting God as seamstress. As Tribble argues, as

Yahweh takes on the feminine roles of midwife, seamstress, housekeeper, nurse, and mother, God is not male. Hence, in order for both genders to coexist, as God is depicted not only with male pronouns, but also with gynomorphic language, it only makes sense for the conclusion that God is genderless to naturally follow. This can further be supported as Israel repudiates anthropomorphisms, as the nature of Yahweh is intended to not be defined by sexual activity, procreation or gendered consort relationships. The transcendence of Yahweh is further stipulated in Deuteronomy 6:4, where 'the Lord our God, the Lord is one' emphasising God's singular existence, transcending human limitations, including gender. Thus, the use of both masculine and feminine imagery to describe Yahweh ultimately reveals a God who is not male, and so linguistic limitations should not hinder theological understanding.

However, rejecting the antecedent that 'God is male,' is not, by itself, a sufficient justification to deny the subsequent 'male is God.' This is because the theological question of God's gender is distinct from the sociological reality in which the male conception of God, most evident in the incarnation of Jesus, has been used to legitimize female subordination and male dominance. This can be further emphasised in the misogynistic teachings of the Bible and church where 'women should keep silent in the churches for they are not permitted to speak but should be in submission' (1 Corinthians 14:34) and wives are instructed to 'submit to their husbands as they do to the lord' (Ephesians 5:22-23). Additionally, in Genesis 3 Eve is seen as the source of sin, and Daly argues that the Fall has been used to oppress women, leading to internalised feelings of guilt. Further is God giving power to Adam to name the women Eve hints at women's enslavement to men. Therefore, while God can be interpreted as gender-neutral, within society, women have been demonstrated to be inferior and subjugated by men, and so the man has become elevated in importance.

Nevertheless, one could appeal to Ruether's idea of the golden thread in order to highlight that there is a theme of liberation indicating that we can disentangle from the patriarchal influences and instead redeem the gynocentric messages of the bible. While it is undeniable there are sexist undertones, Ruether indicates that we need to separate the patriarchal notions from authentic teachings which

support feminism. The prophetic liberating tradition includes God's defence of the oppressed such as freeing the Jews in Exodus, Jesus' treatment of the marginalised, such as women, Jesus' criticisms of the established religious views that justify the dominant, unjust social order and Jesus' moral teachings like the commandment of agape. This argument is contingent on the assumption that a plausible reading of the messiah's actions is that they were aimed at liberating women. This can be exemplified when Jesus visits the home of sisters Mary and Martha, where Martha is busy with domestic tasks and Mary decides to sit at Jesus' feet listening to him. While Martha is annoyed that Mary is not helping her, Jesus replies that 'there is need of only one thing' of which 'Mary has chosen the better part' perhaps hinting that Jesus viewed women in a spiritually equal light and was against traditional social gender roles that saw women as inferior to men.

Ruther's argument can further be supported as she calls Jesus a 'pro-feminist' and not a 'feminist' since feminism, as a concept, did not exist in the 1st century. Since we must consider context, we should judge Jesus relative to his own historical context, therefore it would be unreasonable to expect Jesus to make explicitly feminist statements. Instead, the more valid approach would be to examine if Jesus' actions worked against patriarchy. Examples such as how he treated women with dignity and equality points to the idea that there is something in Jesus' ministry that assertively resists patriarchy, even if not overtly deemed feminist. Hence, it can be argued that although the Bible was written in a deeply patriarchal society, Jesus' actions can be heuristically interpreted as feminist, demonstrating that we can redeem the Bible and break down the association of maleness with divinity.

However, Daly would deem this as an unsuccessful argument since she argued that it is impossible for a male saviour like Jesus to liberate women, as his masculinity is a defining feature of what makes him the Christian ideal. In this narrative, for a woman to be saved she must suppress or deny her basic female nature and conform to a male-oriented standard of holiness. This is reflected in the structure of the Church itself, where women can only achieve salvation through men, since only male priests are permitted to represent Christ at the altar. For example, in Catholicism, the priest is understood to act *in persona Christi* ("in the person of Christ") during the Eucharist; a role restricted

exclusively to men on the grounds that Christ was male. Similarly, the exclusion of women from the priesthood or from positions of ecclesial authority reinforces the idea that men are inherently closer to God because of their physical resemblance to Jesus. Daly points to this dynamic as evidence that Christianity, in its traditional form, cannot serve as a vehicle for female liberation; rather, it entrenches patriarchal norms. The male saviour becomes a model that women must emulate by negating aspects of themselves, while men are valorised as naturally possessing divine likeness. This is further strengthened by doctrines that elevate Virgin Mary as an ideal of obedience, virginity, and submission, qualities that contrast with the active, authoritative model represented by Christ. Therefore, as put forward by Daly, this confines women to subordinate roles within both theology and society.

While society might have previously excluded women from taking on typically male-dominated roles, we can convincingly contend that, as a society, we have evolved and reinterpreted the Bible to better respect women's rights and dignity. From a liberal protestant viewpoint, women are able to hold positions of power within churches through their roles of ministers, bishops and priests. The Church of England ordains women as priests since 1994 and bishops since 2015, exemplified by Libby Lane becoming the first female bishop in the Church of England, and the evangelical Lutheran church has ordained women since 1970. The liberal protestant view also places less emphasis on the Virgin Mary, rejecting that the sole purpose of a woman 'theotokos' and indicating that Mary should not overshadow Christ or become a focus of worship. Due to the progressions made within Christianity detailing that women can fulfil roles typically dominated by men, and the possibility for women to occupy leadership roles, it can be argued that the male is not God.

As a result, Daly's argument can be critiqued, first by detailing that the notion of God as male is a product of a patriarchal society, and secondly that through reclaiming the Bible's liberating core, women can occupy leadership roles once reserved by men. Hence, it has been persuasively demonstrated that God is not male, and the male is not God.

